

Key Takeaways: The connection between disability and poverty and tools to assist

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There is a cyclical nature to poverty and disability. People living in poverty have less access to healthcare, preventative services, and healthy living conditions. People with disabilities are often underemployed or unemployed, experience barriers to education and skills development opportunities, and have additional disability-related issues, all of which contribute to poverty.

Financial literacy education and asset development are tools state agencies and their partners can use to promote and encourage financial stability, both among individuals with disabilities and the front-line staff who help lift individuals out of poverty. To help, state systems should:

- » Collaborate with educational systems, local businesses and financial institutions, disability advocacy groups, provider agencies, and centers for independent living to ensure individuals are receiving resources and tools about financial literacy and asset development.
- » Learn about programs and efforts in other states, such as outreach projects conducted with universities or training provided by personnel at banks and credit unions.
- » Acknowledge that many support workers live at or below the poverty level and need to develop their own understanding of financial stability to better support individuals with disabilities.
- » Encourage financial planning objectives and skills early in life in individual education program, individual support planning, and person-centered planning meetings. Include reminders to regularly address financial planning at future meetings. Demonstrate the positive effects of financial planning by sharing success stories.
- » Train service coordinators, teachers, and other support providers on the Affording a Better Life Experience (ABLE) Act so they may share it with individuals and families.

SELN Hub members can navigate to the [Monthly Network Meeting groups page](#) for additional materials and discussion.

[Meeting Recording](#)



State Employment Leadership Network

The SELN is a place for states to connect, collaborate, and create cross-community support regarding pressing employment-related issues at state and federal levels for individuals with developmental disabilities.

The SELN was launched in 2006 as a joint program of the National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services and the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston.



NASDDDS

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What's the ABLE Act?

The ABLE Act allows people with disabilities and their families to open tax-advantaged savings accounts that help people save for disability-related expenses without risking the loss of public benefits like Medicaid. Allowable expenses include education, housing, transportation, employment training and support, preventative healthcare, and basic living expenses.

Individuals may choose to enroll in their own state program, or they may opt to enroll in any of the states that offer ABLE accounts.

Resources

[The ABLE National Resource Center](#)

[FDIC Money Smart Program](#)

[US Department of Labor Skills to Pay the Bills](#)